

Iterative vs single-prompt approach

Activity · Prompting techniques · ~30 min

Before you start

- ☐ You've worked through **Build a clear prompt** and **Explore with the AI Assistant**
- ☐ The AI Assistant is open in your country's project

Why this matters

There are two valid ways to get the AI to produce a structured output: build it up across several messages (iterative), or front-load everything into one well-structured prompt (single). Both work. The trade-off is **control vs speed**. This exercise lets you feel the difference on the same task.

Exercise A — Iterative conversation

Build a short data quality report by stepping through these four prompts **in order**. Wait for the AI's response after each before sending the next:

1. *Can you help me understand the quality of our 2024 data? I'd like a 3-slide summary I can share with my team.*
2. *Let's focus on overall quality, regional differences, and priorities for improvement.*
3. *Which region has the weakest data quality? Highlight that.*
4. *What should we do about this? Make the final slide more actionable.*

Exercise B — Single well-structured prompt

Now generate the **same** 3-slide report using one prompt. Open a fresh AI conversation and paste:

Build a 3-slide data quality report for 2024 covering (1) overall status, (2) regional comparison, and (3) recommendations.

Reflection

After running both exercises, answer:

- How did the outputs differ between the iterative path and the single prompt?
- Which approach felt easier or more natural for *this* task?
- Where did the AI make assumptions that needed clarification?

When to use each

Use iterative when...	Use a single prompt when...
You're not sure exactly what you want	You know exactly what you want
You want to react to what the AI produces along the way	You want the AI to commit to a structure up front
You're exploring or experimenting	You're producing something repeatable (e.g., a recurring report)

Both approaches use the same underlying data and methods — neither is "better" in general. Match the approach to the task.

What's next

Move on to **Refine your prompt** for a self-paced exercise on tightening a single prompt across three rounds.